

How to Connect to the RAGtime MCP Server: A Step-by-Step Guide

"Connecting" to the RAGtime MCP server means giving Claude permission to search RAGtime for you, so you can ask Claude questions and get answers that cite real documents.

Start here: which way should you connect?

Most people should use **Path A**, the Claude website or app. It takes about two minutes and needs no passwords.

If you...	Use	Time
Use Claude in a web browser or the Claude app	Path A	About 2 minutes
Use Claude Code , the version of Claude you type into in a text window on your computer	Path B	About 10 minutes, once

Not sure? Use Path A.

Before you start

You need the items below. You do not need to know how to code.

For Path A (Claude website or app)

- ☐ You can sign in to Claude with your **Lawfare** email.

For Path B (Claude Code), the above, plus:

- ☐ A Mac or Windows computer you're allowed to install apps on.
- ☐ RAGtime turned on in your Claude account (Path A, steps 1-4).

Path A: Turn on RAGtime in the Claude website or app

Lawfare's Claude administrator has already added RAGtime for everyone at Lawfare. All you do is switch it on. You never type a password.

1. Go to **claude.ai** and sign in with your Lawfare account.

2. Click your **name or initials** in the bottom-left corner, then click **Settings**.
3. Click **Connectors**.
4. Find **RAGtime** in the list. If it says **Connect**, click it and follow the prompts. If it already says **Connected**, skip to step 5.
5. Start a **new chat**.
6. Below the message box, click the **tools button** (it looks like a slider or a plus sign) and make sure **RAGtime** is switched on.
7. Ask a test question. See *Check that it worked* below.

The Claude desktop and phone apps use the same account. Once RAGtime is on at claude.ai, it's on in the apps too.

Don't see RAGtime under Connectors? Your account may not be in Lawfare's Claude organization yet. Ask the RAGtime team, who will check with the Claude administrator.

Path B: Use RAGtime in Claude Code

Claude Code is a version of Claude you type into in a text window on your computer. You don't need to be a programmer to use it. RAGtime comes into Claude Code **automatically** from your Lawfare Claude account, so there is nothing to copy, download or configure, and no password.

One step uses **Terminal** (Mac) or **PowerShell** (Windows), the built-in text-command apps. When a step says "paste this," copy the grey text exactly, paste it, and press **Return** (Mac) or **Enter** (Windows).

- **Open Terminal on a Mac:** press **Command (⌘) + Space**, type **Terminal**, and press **Return**.
- **Open PowerShell on Windows:** click **Start**, type **PowerShell**, and press **Enter**.

One-time setup (about 10 minutes)

1. **Turn RAGtime on in your Claude account first.** Follow Path A, steps 1–4. Claude Code uses the same account, so this is what makes RAGtime show up there.
2. **Install Claude Code.** Paste the line for your computer:
 - Mac:

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

- Windows:

```
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

When it finishes, close the window and open it again.

- 3. **Start Claude Code.** Paste `claude` and press Return or Enter.
- 4. **Sign in.** Claude Code asks how you want to sign in. Choose the option to sign in with your **Claude account** (not an API key). A browser window opens: sign in with your **Lawfare** email and approve. Then go back to the Terminal or PowerShell window.
- 5. **Check RAGtime is there.** Type `/mcp` and press Return or Enter. You should see **claude.ai RAGtime** marked as connected. Press **Esc** to close the list.

Every time you want to use RAGtime

- 1. Open Terminal (Mac) or PowerShell (Windows).
- 2. Paste `claude` and press Return or Enter.
- 3. Ask your question. RAGtime is already connected.

To leave Claude Code, type `/exit`.

Check that it worked

Ask Claude this:

Using RAGtime, how many OLC opinions are in the corpus, and what’s the date range?

It worked if Claude says it is using a RAGtime tool (you may see a small note such as "get_facets") and answers with a number of opinions and a range of dates. If Claude answers from general knowledge without mentioning RAGtime, see *Troubleshooting* below.

RAGtime has two levels of tools:

Level	What it does	Examples	Who gets it
Free	Finds and opens documents	Keyword search, filters, fetching a document, reading court filings	Everyone who is connected

Level	What it does	Examples	Who gets it
AI	Has RAGtime do the research and write answers	Asking a whole corpus a question, summarizing a document, finding similar documents	Everyone who is connected, on either path

AI requests come from Lawfare's shared allowance of **5,000 a day**, which resets daily. Both paths draw on it.

Troubleshooting

What you see	What it means	What to do
Claude answers without mentioning RAGtime	RAGtime isn't switched on	Path A: click the tools button under the message box and switch RAGtime on. Path B: type <code>/mcp</code> and check that claude.ai RAGtime is connected.
RAGtime isn't listed under Settings → Connectors	Your account isn't in Lawfare's Claude organization yet	Ask the RAGtime team.
<code>/mcp</code> in Claude Code doesn't list claude.ai RAGtime	Claude Code is signed in to a different account, or RAGtime isn't on in your Claude account	Do Path A, steps 1–4. Then in Claude Code type <code>/logout</code> , then <code>/login</code> , and sign in with your Lawfare email.
AI tools stop working, but search still works	Lawfare's daily AI allowance is used up	Try again tomorrow, or tell the RAGtime team.
"command not found: claude" (Mac) or "claude is not recognized" (Windows)	Claude Code isn't installed, or the window needs reopening	Close and reopen Terminal or PowerShell. If that doesn't help, redo Path B step 2.
A newly added RAGtime collection doesn't appear	Claude loaded RAGtime's old list when the chat started	Start a new chat (Path A), or quit Claude Code with <code>/exit</code> and start it again (Path B)

Directions generated from a Claude Code session.